



THE FLINTLOCK YEARS

1650–1830

The flintlock mechanism appeared in the late 16th century. It was cheaper and simpler than the wheel-lock, and produced sparks by striking a piece of flint onto a piece of hardened steel. By around 1650, it was being used widely in Europe and North America, although matchlock and wheel-lock guns remained in use. Employed on firearms ranging from pistols to artillery, the flintlock would continue to be the principal firing mechanism for more than 200 years.